

A NEW CLEAN SLATE

Many undistinguished schools which cater to the poorest sections of society have rewritten their humiliating history this year, thanks to a special scheme launched by the state Government

Photographs by SHANKAR



■ **By M.G. Radhakrishnan**

The star at Kozhikode's NGO Quarters Government High School is a 15-year-old girl appropriately named Shine Gopal. Last year was one of ignominy for her school as 34 of its 52 students, who sat for the Class X examination, failed, taking the school down to the ranks of the state's worst performers. Thanks to the collective efforts of Shine and her friends—with some help from the Government—the school's pass percentage has climbed from last year's 33 to a decent 70 per cent. But Shine is unique. The Dalit girl stays at the Government-run After Care Home for destitute women and orphaned girls and is the only successful candidate among the 10 inmates of the home who sat for the examination. "I will study hard. I want to become a police woman," she beams.

Shine's school is one of the 104 high schools that cater to the poorest sections of the state, most of which

have rewritten their humiliating history this year, thanks to a special adoption scheme of the state Education Department. The scheme, named "Quality Education is Pupil's Right" (QEPR), was implemented in the state's bottom 104 schools—both government owned and private aided—which had the lowest success rate. The result of QEPR, which cost barely Rs 1

NEW CHAPTER

The steps that were taken by the Government and local communities to improve standards included:

- Rs 1 lakh each for the 104 schools.
- Special meals for Class X students.
- Special morning and evening classes.
- Tutorial for weak students.
- Mentoring for small groups.
- Peer group sessions.
- Counselling for parents.
- Setting up of groups of parents to hold night classes.

LAST LAUGH: The students have come a long way from failure

crore for the state exchequer, have been both amazing and quick. Most schools have registered a success rate of 50 per cent. Five of them have even scored a perfect 100 per cent. The achievement has been the result of a collective endeavour by the Government, teachers, students, parents, old students, the panchayats and also the local community. Says Education Minister and architect of QEPR, M.A. Baby, "Credit must go to these children and their dedicated teachers since many of the schools achieved this feat even without spending the full amount they were entitled to."

QEPR was formulated on the basis of a study conducted on the schools catering to weaker sections of society by the State Council of Educational Research and Training (SCERT). The Council listed out several factors like availability, quality and qualification of teachers, schools'